



Ellora Caves

A cave complex in which three Eastern religions co-exist, famous for its sculptures and massive rock-cut Kailasa temple

India is home to three of the world's religions: Buddhism, Hinduism, and Jainism. The three traditions are brought together at the vast Ellora Cave complex in Maharashtra, western India. The site comprises 34 hand-carved, rock-cut temple caves built between the 7th and 11th centuries CE. Spread over 1.2 miles (2 km), they are most famous for the massive sculptures of deities.

The centerpiece of the complex is the spectacular 8th-century Kailasa temple, dedicated to the Hindu god Shiva. Off the courtyard are galleries filled with carvings and sculptural friezes, which narrate tales from the sacred Hindu texts, the *Ramayana* and the *Mahabharata*.



▽ CAREFULLY CARVED

The massive Kailasa temple, one of India's largest and most elaborate rock-cut temples, was excavated from the top downward, creating a magnificent free-standing structure.

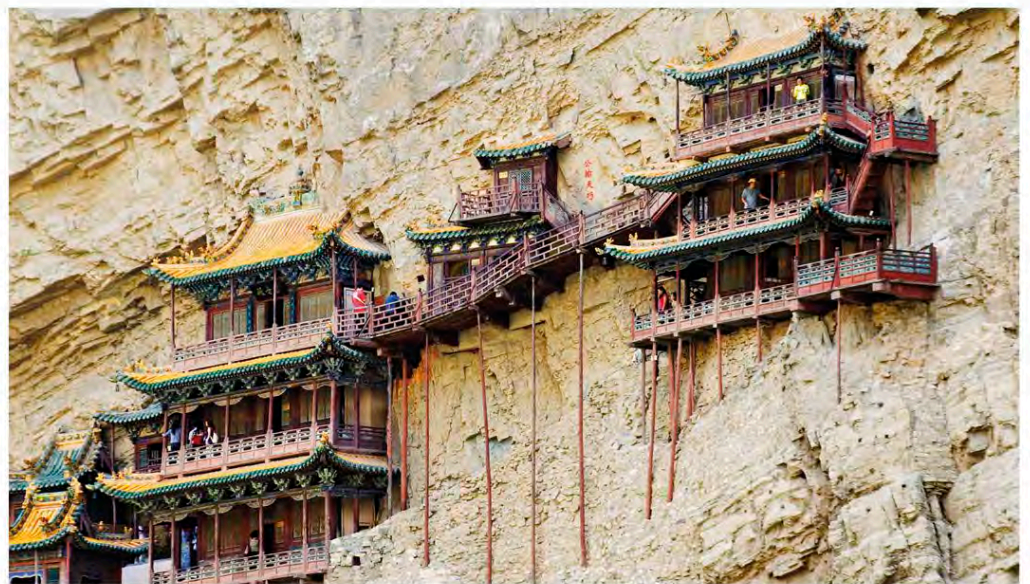
The **Kailasa temple** is believed to have been excavated **out of a single rock**



The Hanging Temple

A precariously positioned temple that represents three of China's principal religions and schools of thought

Hengshan mountain, in Shanxi province, is the northernmost of China's sacred Five Great Mountains; clinging precariously to its side is the legendary Hanging Temple. Seeming to defy gravity, the structure is suspended some 246 ft (75 m) from the ground, with its 40 rooms secured by wooden crossbeams wedged into the cliff-face. The temple's pagodalike structures are linked to each other and the various halls by a maze of ramps, staircases, rickety passages, and walkways. The complex is thought to have been constructed



during the Northern Wei dynasty (386–534/535 CE), although significant renovations and expansions were undertaken in the Ming (1368–1644) and Qing (1644–1912) dynasties.

In addition to its precipitous location, the wooden temple complex is notable for representing three of China's principal religions or schools of thought side by side: Buddhism, Daoism, and Confucianism, whose founders (Siddhartha Gautama, Laozi, and Confucius, respectively) are depicted in harmonious cohabitation in statues in the temple's northern Sanjiao Hall.

△ BALANCING ACT

Suspended on the side of Hengshan mountain above Jinlong Canyon, the temple buildings are secured by long, thin wooden poles that have been fastened into the near-vertical cliff-face.